

READING THE RIOT ACT

In the backdrop of the suicide attack at its Kabul mission and the violation of ceasefire, India turns the heat on Pakistan as the two premiers meet on the sidelines of the SAARC Summit

■ By Saurabh Shukla in Colombo

In normal days too, the Sri Lankan capital resembles an army garrison, with paratroopers and anti-aircraft guns mounted on rooftops and deep body searches almost every hundred yards. But as the leaders of the eight-member South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation (SAARC) gathered in Colombo for their annual summit, the capital resembled a fortress.

With the attack on the late Indian prime minister Rajiv Gandhi on his last visit to Colombo still lingering on in the minds of security agencies, followed by his assassination by the banned organisation, Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam (LTTE), India flew in IAF choppers to ferry Prime Minister Manmohan Singh. Meanwhile, two Indian warships also maintained a close watch 12 nautical miles off the Sri Lankan coast and air force jets were ready to scramble.

Barring a minor security goofup involving National Security Adviser M.K. Narayanan, what dominated the agenda was the tête-à-tête between Manmohan and his Pakistani counterpart Yusuf Raza Gilani, on the heels of a new low in their relationship. On August 2, when they met in the sixth-floor lounge of the Taj Samudra hotel, surrounded by only a handful of aides, the atmosphere was tense. The 45-minute meeting came in the backdrop of the recent chill in Indo-Pak ties with India blaming Pakistani intelligence agency Inter-Services Intelligence (ISI), for orchestrating the last month's attack on its mission in Kabul that killed

more than 40 people, including two Indian diplomats. "Both sides expressed determination to overcome these events and move back on track for improving relations," remarked Foreign Secretary Shivshankar Menon.

Notwithstanding public statements, the meeting turned out to be one of the most tense of all recent Indo-Pak exchanges at the highest level, remarked officials who were present at the discussions. The Indian prime minister, normally a soft-spoken man but brimming with confidence after winning the trust vote, was candid in cornering Gilani over the alleged involvement of the ISI in various attacks on India. He referred to the suicide attack on the Kabul mission, the violation of the ceasefire on the Line of Control (LoC) and bomb blasts in Indian cities. "There cannot be business as usual. Unless you take corrective measures, it will be difficult to take the dialogue process forward," Manmohan told Gilani, according to a senior diplomat.

The Pakistani prime minister explained, "We want good ties, and confidence building measures should continue." But Manmohan struck back saying, "Maintaining ceasefire on the LoC was the strongest confidence building measure and you violated it." He firmly asked his Pakistani counterpart to probe the suicide bombing in Kabul, and Gilani nodded. Talking to INDIA TODAY immediately after the meeting, Gilani put up a brave face and remarked, "It was cordial and frank. We had a good meeting and they have expressed some concerns." When asked

AP PHOTO GURINDER OSAN



TESTING TIMES: Manmohan, Gilani in Colombo (above); Karzai in Delhi



COLOMBO CANDOUR

Under pressure from India, the Colombo Summit issued a strong statement condemning terrorism

■ India tells Pakistan there cannot be business as usual if it does not take concrete measures to stop terrorism in the region

■ India to go full throttle against Pak-sponsored terrorism. Unfazed by embassy attack, it announces fresh aid of \$450 million to Kabul.

■ For now, dialogue process will continue, but India will work in close coordination with the US, Afghanistan and friendly countries to counter Pak-based terror groups